

Will AI Replace Teachers? The 2026 Teaching Degree Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

3.6

AI EXPOSURE · ELEMENTARY / EARLY YEARS

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

Quick answer: Classroom teaching scores **3.6 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk — one of the lower scores in this index. Special education scores **3.1**. But online instruction and content-based tutoring score **6.8**, nearly double. A classroom is not an information-delivery problem, which is exactly why teaching through a screen is on a completely different trajectory.

The short answer for parents: yes, and AI is on balance good news for classroom teachers. It automates the marking, planning and paperwork that drive people out of the profession, while leaving the part that drew them in. The caution is that education-adjacent careers built on content delivery share the online track's exposure, not the classroom's protection.

Teaching AI risk score by setting

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a teacher and a paramedic.

SETTING	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
Special education	2.7	2.9	3.1	+0.4	Low
Elementary / early years	3.2	3.4	3.6	+0.4	Low
Secondary — STEM subjects	3.4	3.6	3.8	+0.4	Low
Secondary — general subjects	3.7	3.9	4.1	+0.4	Low–Moderate
Online instruction / tutoring	5.5	6.2	6.8	+1.3	Moderate–High

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**.

Classroom teaching's +0.4 over three years is tied for the slowest movement in the index. Online instruction moved +1.3 over the same period — the same skill, delivered through a screen, on a completely different trajectory. No pair we score shows more clearly that **setting is destiny**.

Will AI replace teachers?

Not in a classroom. AI tutors are already good at explaining content patiently and infinitely — which turns out to be a small fraction of what a teacher does.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Lesson planning and resource creation	Holding a room of thirty children
Marking and feedback generation	Noticing the kid who has gone quiet this week
Differentiating materials by level	Managing the social world of a classroom
Parent communication drafts	Being the adult a child trusts
Administrative reporting	Knowing why this student is stuck
Curriculum mapping	Everything schools do that isn't teaching

Adoption is already near-universal — the large majority of teachers and students used AI in the last school year, and most teachers who did reported it improved their teaching and gave them more time with students.

For a profession with a retention crisis, that matters. The tasks being automated are the ones people cite when they leave.

Why does teaching score low? The six factors

How elementary classroom teaching rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	7.7	↑ high exposure
How hard will it be to land that first job?	1.5	↓ strongest protection
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	9.0	↓ strong protection
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	9.5	↓ strong protection
Does the law require a licensed human?	8.0	↓ strong protection
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	7.5	↓ good protection

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.

How much of this job can AI already do? — rated 7.7, and why a high rating doesn't produce a high score

This is the factor that carries the most weight in our model at 35%, and teaching is the clearest case in the whole index of it being outweighed.

Teaching rates 7.7 on automatability — higher than nursing, higher than medicine, higher than most careers we score. A very large share of a teacher's working hours goes to planning, resource creation, differentiation, marking, feedback and administrative reporting. Nearly all of it is now automatable, and much of it is already being automated in practice.

If our model let automatability alone drive the score, teaching would sit in the moderate-to-high band alongside marketing and business analysis.

It doesn't, because the other five factors run strongly the other way. Presence rates 9.0 — a classroom is embodied, social work. Trust rates 9.5, because parents hand over their children, which is not a relationship anyone delegates to software. Certification is mandated, and the entry route requires classroom practice. And schools perform a custodial and social function that has nothing to do with information transfer at all.

The design choice that produces this result is deliberate. Our three protection factors carry 50% of the weight in total — more than automatability's 35%. That means protection *can* outweigh exposure. If we had weighted exposure more heavily, teaching would score high and the model would be wrong.

And it is exactly why the online track scores 6.8. Take the identical subject knowledge and identical automatable tasks, strip out presence, weaken trust, remove certification

requirements, and the same 7.7 automatability rating now dominates. Nothing about the work changed. The setting did.

Which teaching roles are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Special education — 3.1.** Maximum physical presence, individualized judgment, deep trust and legal accountability. 2. **Elementary / early years — 3.6.** Social and custodial as much as instructional. 3. **Secondary STEM — 3.8.** Persistent shortages add market protection on top. 4. **Secondary general — 4.1.** More content-delivery-shaped than the above, though still classroom-protected. 5. **Online instruction / tutoring — 6.8.** Competing directly with free AI that explains content well.

Is teaching a good career in 2026?

The AI question here is genuinely positive, and the difficult questions are the perennial ones.

Teaching has some of the strongest structural protection in this index — certification, presence, trust, and shortages in most regions, especially in math, science, special education and bilingual instruction. Landing a first job is among the easiest of any career we score.

What has not changed: workload, where the visible hours are a fraction of the real ones. Behavior management, which is harder than most people expect. Pay that lags comparable graduate careers. And high early-career attrition.

AI plausibly improves the first of those. It does nothing for the rest.

One thing worth asking any teacher-training program: how do they prepare candidates to use these tools well? Under half of teachers report receiving any institutional training or guidance on AI, which means a newly-qualified teacher who is genuinely fluent walks into a shortage market with a real edge.

Common questions

Will AI replace teachers? Not in classrooms. A room of thirty children is a human problem rather than an information problem, and schools do far more than transmit content. Online instruction is a different matter.

Is teaching a safe career from AI? Among the safer ones — 3.6 for elementary classroom teaching against a median of about 5.5. Special education is safer still.

Will AI tutors replace teachers? They compete with paid tutoring far more than with classroom teaching. That is why online instruction scores 6.8 while the classroom scores 3.6.

Is teaching improved by AI? On the evidence so far, yes for classroom teachers. It automates planning, marking and differentiation — the tasks most cited by people leaving the profession — while leaving the human work intact.

Should my child avoid education-adjacent careers? Be careful with the ones built on content delivery. Tutoring businesses, online course instruction and test prep share the online track's exposure rather than the classroom's protection.

Related profiles

- [Psychology](#) — 3.5 licensed clinical, 7.1 with the degree alone
- [Nursing](#) — 2.8 bedside, 5.4 desk-based
- [Social work](#) — coming in this edition
- [Business and management](#) — 7.6 analyst, 4.9 leadership
- [Computer science](#) — 8.1 entry-level, 5.4 senior. Free to read in full.

What's in the full teaching profile

This sampler tells you where teaching stands. The full profile tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	FULL PROFILE
Verdict, all setting scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is		✓
The honest downsides — workload, pay, behavior, attrition		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Routes in — education degree, subject degree plus certification, alternative routes		✓
Where the degree leads later — including the exposed adjacent careers		✓
Program evaluation checklist — placement, AI preparation, subject shortages		✓
Questions to ask a program — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

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Each full profile includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. Spring 2027 updates of whatever you buy are included.

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Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.